Punjab, Haryana, Gujarat, Himachal Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh use it to try and illegally migrate to the West, mainly the US, with the help of traffickers. A combination of reasons push them to take this extreme and desperate step: low wages, the moribund farming sector, lack of opportunity even after getting a college degree and the lure of a good life abroad, with the prestige it would confer. The massive demand for migration to the West has spawned a whole industry of touts, traffickers and hustlers in these states. The monetary sacrifices made are huge too—traffickers can charge anything from Rs 25 lakh to over a crore. There is no reimbursement of the amount if a client is caught while crossing the border and deported. Deepak's friends had allegedly spent Rs 55 lakh on just the donkers' services.

HOW IT WORKS

Traffickers and donkers have various ways to secrete their clients well within sight of the US border, whether from Canada in the north or Mexico in the south, before asking them to make a run for it. In the recent past, donkers would arrange tourist visas for migrants in the countries through which they would pass. There were also such dangerous methods as being transported in containers. In the new, preferred method, migrants first fly to a country in the region, especially those that issue visas on arrival in an easy process. Often, the route to reach that country, like the one Deepak took, has pit stops in nations in Central and West Asia, South and Central America. At the final stage of the journey, donkers use two or three different routes to help illegal immigrants cross into the US through its borders with Canada or Mexico. The most favoured route to cross into the US is the southern one, and it involves moving through South and Central American nations towards the final launching pad in Mexico.

A particularly dangerous route involves groups of migrants being made to move through the jungles of Panama—seething with wild animals, snakes and, worst of all, ruthless drug mafia—over several days. Surviving the 'Darien Gap'—which connects South (Colombia) with Central (Panama) America—is thought to be among the most challenging stages. Migrants are often abandoned, and left to die without access to food or water. According to survivors who made it, the trail is littered with corpses of illegal migrants who failed in other attempts. "Once you are lucky enough to survive the deadly Panama jungles, you move to Costa Rica. Days of trekking through the dense forests of El Salvador and Guatemala follow before reaching Mexico," says a Delhi Police officer. On the US-Mexico border, he adds, illegal migrants can be apprehended by security officers, or run the risk of being shot. In 2021, 2,600 Indian nationals were caught by the US authorities at the border.

A DASH ACROSS THREE CONTINENTS



1 **Jan. 6** Kolkata to Dubai, UAE

2 **Feb. 2** Alamaty, KZK to Istanbul, Turkey

3 **Feb. 5** Istanbul to Panama City

4 **Feb. 5** Panama City to Port of Spain

DONKEY ROUTE
The illegal routes adopted by human trafficking cartels to push migrants into western nations–primarily the US, Canada and western Europe. The most used route from South Asia to the US has multiple stops in nations spanning Central and West Asia, the West Indies and Central America, before it enters Mexico. The route through Panama, Costa Rica, El Salvador and Guatemala involves dangerous tracks through jungles.

THE HUNT FOR DEEPAK BOXER

Deepak too had made it to El Salvador, where he was picked up by Pakistani national Ali, a donker settled in Mexico. Ali arranged a taxi for Deepak to travel from El Salvador to Mexico. Once the Delhi Police tracked Boxer to Cancun in Mexico, the joint operation, which was codenamed Operation Mexico, was launched, in cooperation with the FBI, the Mexican police, Interpol and the Delhi Police special cell. Mexican authorities feared that being an experienced hitman, Deepak would make his way into a criminal racket in